

Emotions in Gaelic Grammar

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Background

Experiencers show a range of anomalous properties crosslinguistically, giving rise to much work in the literature. (Postal, 1971, Perlmutter, 1983, Belletti and Rizzi, 1988, Pesetsky, 1995, Landau, 2009).

- (1) (a) John fears tigers.
(b) Tigers frighten John.

Q1. How are Experiencers expressed in Gaelic?

- (2) Tha an cù anns a' ghàradh
Be-PRE the dog in the garden
'The dog is in the garden.'

- (3) Tha mi brònach
be-PRES I sad
'I am sad.'

- (4) Tha mi fo chùram
Be-PRE I under anxiety
'I am anxious.'

- (5) Tha cùram orm
be-PRES anxiety on + me
'I am anxious.'

- (6) Tha eagal orm
be-PRES fear on + me
'I am afraid.'

- (7) Tha dragh agam
Be-PRES vexation aig + me
'I am annoyed.'

- (8) Tha gaol agam ort
Be-PRES love at + me on + you
'I love you.'

Q2. What is the superficial link between experiencers and locations and locations and possessors in the language?

- (9) Tha am ministear aig an doras
Be-PRES the minister at the door
'The minister is at the door.'
- (10) Tha peann aig Dàibhidh
Be-PRES pen at David
'I have a pen.'
- (11) (a) Tha an leabhar air a' bhòrd
be-PRES the book on the table
'The book is on the table.'
(b) Tha fearg orm
be-PRES anger on+me
'I am angry.'
- (12) Tha ceann mòr air Dàibhidh
Be-PRES head big on David
'David has a big head'

Q3. Focus: what do the following show in terms of constituency of the emotion and the experiencer vs source? Why is this puzzling given the word order of simple experiencer sentences?

- (13) Chan eil agam ach gaol ort
Neg be at-me but love for-you
'I have nothing but love for you.'
- (14) *Chan eil ort ach gaol agam
Neg be on-you but love at-me
- (15) 's e gaol air Iain a th' agam
Its love on Iain that is at-me
'I love Iain.'
- (16) *'s e gaol aig Iain a th' orm
Its love at Iain that is on-me
'Iain loves me.'

Q4. What do the following show about the c-command relationship between experiencer and source?

- (17) Tha gaol agam orm-fhèin.
Be-PRES love at-1 SG on-1 SG-self
'I love myself.'
- (18) *Tha gaol agam-fhèin orm.
Be-PRES love at-1 SG-self on-1 SG
'I love myself.'

Q5. Selection: assume that nouns select their complements. What does the following data suggest about the relation between noun and source?

- (19) Cha robh dragh aice dhiotsa.
Neg Be-PAST worry at-3FSG off-2SG
'She wasn't worried about you.'
- (20) Tha gaol agam ort.
Be-PRES love at-1SG on-2SG
'I love you.'
- (21) Tha sùil agam ann.
Be-PRES eye at-1SG on-3.M.SG
'I fancy him.'
- (22) Tha tlachd aig Iain do Pheigi.
Be-PRES attachment at Iain to Peggy
'Ian is fond of Peggy.'
- (23) Tha fuath aig Iain do Pheigi.
Be-PRES hate at Iain to Peggy
'Ian hates Peggy.'
- (24) Bha truas aice ris.
Be-PRES pity at-3FS to-3ms
'She pities him'
- (25) Tha dòchas aca gum bidh iad trath.
Be-PRES hope at-3PL that be-FUT they early
'They hope that they will be early.'

Q6. Are the following a challenge for the conclusion you just drew? If so, how?

- (26) Bith gaol mòr aig Iain air Mairi
Be love great at John on Mary
'John loves Mary greatly.'

Q7. Gaelic is VSO:

- (27) Dhùn Màiri an doras
Shut Mary the door
'Mary shut the door.'

What happens to VSO order in an embedded non-finite clause?

- (28) Bu toigh leam [Màiri a bhith a' dùnadh an dorais]
be liking with-me Mary prt be-VN ASP shut-VN the door-GEN
'I'd like Mary to shut the door.'

Q8. What does the following suggest about the status of the emotion noun?

- (29) Bu toigh leam [gaol a bhith agam ort]
Cop liking with-me love prt be at-me on-you
'I wish I loved you.'

Q9. What do the following sentences suggest about the status of the emotion noun?

- (30) Bith Iain an comhnaidh a' snamh
Be John always asp swimming
'John is always swimming.'
- (31) Bith gaol an comhnaidh aig Iain air Mairi
Be love always at John on Mary
'John will always love Mary.'

Q10. Transitive emotion nouns can drop one of their arguments. Does this change your hypothesis about what is going on?

- | | |
|---|---|
| (32) Tha gaol orm.
Be-PRES love on-1 SG
'I am loved.' | (33) *Tha gaol agam.
Be-PRES love at-1 SG
'I love.' |
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Q11. Look at the following sentences with intransitive emotion nouns. Why are there two arguments with these?

- (34) Chuir e fearg orm.
Put-PAST he anger on-1 SG
'He made me angry.'
- (35) Chuir e cùram orm.
Put-PAST he anxiety on-1 SG
'He worried me.'
- (36) Chuir e eagal orm.
Put-PAST he fear on-1 SG
'He frightened me.'

Q12. Why do transitive emotion nouns not behave the same?

- (37) *Chuir e gaol agam air.
Put-PAST he love at-1 SG on-sc 3sg
'He made me love him.'
- (38) *Chuir e dragh agam (dhìot).
Put-PAST he worry at-1 SG (on-2SG)
'He made me worry (about you).'

- (39) *Chuir e peann agam.
Put-PAST he worry at-1 SG
'He gave me a pen.'

Q13. What do you think the structure, in rough terms, of emotion sentences in Gaelic is, as a tree?

References

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